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When Amen Binds and Chesed Is Hidden: Ki Tavo and the Daily Portions of 14 Elul

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The Daily Learning Portions

- **Chumash:** Parshat Ki Tavo, 5th aliyah — Devarim 27:11–28:6
- **Tehillim:** Chapters 72–76 (Elul extra chapters: 40–42 per Hayom Yom / Baal Shem Tov custom)
- **Tanya:** Iggeret HaKodesh, end of Epistle 13
- **Rambam (3 ch.):** Hilchot Parah Adumah, chapters 11–13
- **Sefer HaMitzvot:** Positive Commandment 108 — the laws of *mei niddah* (waters mixed with the ashes of the red heifer)
- **Hayom Yom:** Elul 14 — Fortify the edifice; shun a campaign of attack; actual, not merely potential, *mesirat nefesh*

Seasonal frame. Elul is the month of the King in the Field: accessible, smiling, receiving whoever comes. Shofar is sounded daily. Tefillin and mezuzot are checked. Three extra chapters of Tehillim are recited each day from 1 Elul through Yom Kippur. Today is an ordinary Thursday in an extraordinary month — the day the fifth aliyah of Ki Tavo places six tribes on Gerizim and six on Ebal, binds the nation with *Amen*, and opens the blessings that "come upon you and cleave to you."

I. The Fifth Aliyah: Two Mountains, One Voice, and Blessing That Cleaves

Moses commands the people on that day: when you cross the Jordan, six tribes shall stand on Mount Gerizim to bless the people — Shimon, Levi, Yehudah, Yissachar, Yosef, and Binyamin — and six on Mount Ebal for the curse — Reuven, Gad, Asher, Zevulun, Dan, and Naftali (Devarim 27:11–13). The Levites speak up "in a loud voice" to every individual of Israel. The first spoken line in the list is a curse upon the one who makes a graven or molten image "and sets it up in secret." The people answer: *Amen*.

Rashi, following Sotah 32a, reconstructs the choreography: six tribes on the summit of Gerizim, six on Ebal; kohanim, Levites, and the Ark in the valley between. The Levites turn their faces toward Gerizim for the blessing-form and toward Ebal for the curse-form. Each statement is answered by the whole people. The list that follows is not a random catalogue of sins. It is a map of what a covenant cannot survive if it is done in secret and left unanswered:

- idolatry set up in secret
- degrading father and mother
- moving a neighbor's landmark
- misleading one who is "blind" in a matter
- perverting justice for the stranger, orphan, and widow
- the hidden sexual crimes

- striking a fellow in secret (understood as slander)
- taking a bribe to kill an innocent person
- and the capstone: "Cursed be he who does not uphold the words of this Torah, to fulfill them" (27:26)

Rashi notes that the last line includes the entire Torah. They accepted it upon themselves with curse and oath (Shevuot 36a). Eleven explicit curses correspond, in one reading, to eleven tribes; Shimon is omitted from individual mention, a silence that itself is part of the accounting.

Then the text turns. Chapter 28 does not begin with threat. It begins with a condition and a clinging:

> *"And it will be, if you hearken diligently to the voice of the Lord your G-d, to observe to fulfill all His commandments which I command you this day, the Lord your G-d will set you supreme above all the nations of the earth. And all these blessings shall come upon you and overtake you (ve-hisigucha), if you hearken to the voice of the Lord your G-d." (28:1–2)*

Blessed in the city and in the field. Fruit of womb, soil, and livestock. Basket and kneading-bowl. "Blessed shall you be when you come, and blessed shall you be when you depart" (28:6). Rashi, citing Bava Metzia 107a: may your departure from the world be as free of sin as your entry into it.

Elul reading. Gerizim and Ebal are not scenery. They are the architecture of *bechirah*. The same valley hears blessing and curse. The same mouth says *Amen*. No tribe is permitted to stand only on the pleasant slope. The covenant is public, vocal, and individual — "to every individual of Israel, in a loud voice." Elul is the season in which a person returns to that valley: not to perform the ceremony again, but to recover the inner *Amen* that has gone quiet.

The sins listed are, almost without exception, sins that can be hidden. Idolatry "in secret." Landmark moved by night. Advice that looks helpful and is not. A blow that leaves no bruise because it is slander. Elul's *cheshbon ha-nefesh* is aimed precisely here. The King is in the field; the field is where secret things are done; the King who walks the field is the One who sees them.

The blessings "overtake" the one who hearkens. They are not wages collected at a window. They pursue. In Elul language: when a person turns, the good that was waiting is allowed to catch up. *Teshuvah* does not invent blessing. It stops outrunning it.

II. Tehillim 72–76: Just Kingship, the Problem of the Wicked, and the Judge Who Raises and Lowers

The daily Tehillim for the fourteenth of the month are not incidental to this aliyah.

Psalm 72 is Solomon's prayer — and David's last — for a king who judges the poor with righteousness, whose mountains bear peace, who redeems the needy from oppression. Kingship here is not appetite. It is limited office under Heaven: "May he judge Your people with righteousness, and Your poor with justice." The psalm ends by blessing the Name and filling the earth with His glory. In Elul, this is the inner measure of power — personal power first. A father, a citizen, a teacher, a holder of any small authority asks: does this office redeem the needy, or does it feed itself?

Psalm 73 is Asaph's confession. His feet almost slipped when he saw the prosperity of the wicked. The turning point is sanctuary: "until I entered the sanctuaries of G-d; then I understood their end." Elul *cheshbon* often begins exactly where Asaph began — with the appearance that integrity does not pay. The psalm does not scold the question. It relocates it. Clarity comes not from argument on the slope but from entering the holy place.

Psalm 74 remembers destruction: "They have set Your sanctuary on fire." Elul sits between the mourning of Av and the coronation of Tishrei. The ruined sanctuary is not only historical. It is the inner *Mikdash* a person has neglected. The plea is not nostalgia. It is "Arise, O G-d, plead Your own cause."

Psalm 75 states the political theology of the season in one line: "For G-d is Judge; He puts down one and raises up another." The cup is in the hand of Hashem. Boasting is premature. In a month of *teshuvah*, this is mercy as well as warning. The one who has been lowered can be raised. The one who has been raised can be lowered. Neither condition is a private achievement.

Psalm 76: "In Judah G-d is known; His Name is great in Israel. In Salem also is His tabernacle, and His dwelling-place in Zion." Judgment goes forth from the place of His dwelling. The G-d who is in the field in Elul is not a different G-d from the One whose dwelling is in Zion. Accessibility does not cancel majesty. It reveals it.

Read against Gerizim and Ebal, these five chapters say: kingship is judged; prosperity is not proof; ruin is not the last word; the Judge raises and lowers; His Name is known in Judah. That is sufficient Torah for a Thursday in Elul.

III. Tanya — End of Iggeret HaKodesh, Epistle 13: Hidden Chesed in the Souls of Gevurah

The Alter Rebbe closes Epistle 13 with Tehillim 31:20: "How abundant is Your goodness, which You have hidden away for those who fear You; which You have wrought for those who trust in You, before the sons of man."

Two soul-roots are in view.

Those whose root is from the "right" — *chesed* — are "those who trust in You." Their kindness is manifest, expansive, "before the sons of man." They serve with love. Their good is visible.

Those whose root is from the "left" — *gevurah* — are "those who fear You." Their *chesed* is real, and it is as abundant as the *chesed* of the right. But it is *tov ha-ganuz*, hidden goodness, concealed beneath a dominant surface of *gevurah*. It resembles the trait of Beit Shammai. It is not vested fully in mind and heart, which cannot contain it. It encompasses the person from above, and from there it radiates into mind and heart at the times that require an arousal of that attribute — so that it result in actual deed.

Both degrees of *chesed*, the revealed and the hidden, are "without limit, measure, or dimension."

The parenthetical is decisive for Elul. What is concealed in a soul is not absent. It is *makif*. It waits for the hour that needs it. A person whose charity is customarily limited — the Alter Rebbe's own example — can have the concealed, infinite attribute of *chesed* revealed so that the hand opens.

Elul reading. Elul is precisely such an hour. The King in the Field does not receive only the naturally warm. He receives the *yerei Hashem* whose goodness has been locked under severity, discipline, fear, and self-critique. The work of the month is not to become someone else. It is to let the hidden *chesed* radiate into *ma'aseh be-fo'al mamash* — actual deed.

This also disciplines Elul's inner weather. *Gevurah*-souls in Elul can mistake harshness toward themselves for holiness. The Epistle says the holiness is the hidden *chesed*, not the surface contraction. Fear of Heaven is a root. It is not a license to withhold goodness from wife, children, students, or the poor until one "feels" like a *chesed*-soul. The *makif* is given so that deed can precede mood.

IV. Hayom Yom, 14 Elul: Do Not Attack. Build.

The Frierdiker Rebbe records a directive of the Rebbe Rashab:

> *Keep away — to the ultimate degree — from a campaign of attack. Not because we lack the means of prevailing or because of timorousness, but because we must consecrate all our strength exclusively to strengthening our own structure, the edifice of Torah and mitzvot performed in holiness and purity. To this we must devote ourselves utterly, with actual mesirat nefesh, not merely with potential mesirat nefesh.*

The later adaptation is just as sharp: there are those who devote their energy to fighting darkness. Chassidim prefer to strike a light.

This is not quietism. It is a hierarchy of force. Energy spent on *milchemet tenufah* — a campaign of attack — is energy not spent on the building. The reason given is not weakness. It is consecration. The edifice of Torah and mitzvot in holiness and purity is the assignment. *Mesirat nefesh* that remains "in potential" — the willingness one would show if asked — is not the thing required. The thing required is the actual giving of the day.

Elul reading. *Teshuvah* itself can become a campaign of attack: against one's past, against other Jews' shortcomings, against the darkness one has appointed as the enemy. The Rashab's instruction relocates the labor. Fortify the structure. Put a brick on the building. Learn the portion. Give the tzedakah. Speak the *Amen* that was withheld. Check the mezuzah. Sound the shofar. Sit with a child. The King in the Field is not recruited as an ally in one's private war. He is approached by one who is building.

The distinction between potential and actual *mesirat nefesh* is the Elul distinction between intention and return. Intention is cheap in Elul. Everyone intends to be better by Rosh Hashanah. Actual *mesirat nefesh* is today's hour given to the edifice.

V. Rambam — Parah Adumah 11–13 and Positive Commandment 108: The Water That Purifies and Defiles

The three-chapter cycle today is Hilchot Parah Adumah 11–13. Sefer HaMitzvot assigns Positive Commandment 108: we are commanded regarding the laws of *mei niddah* — the waters mixed with the ashes of the red heifer — which in one respect purify and in another respect defile.

Rambam's chapters at this point in the *halakhot* are technical: what is joined to a vessel for purposes of sprinkling; how sprinkling is valid; the extra stringencies the Sages placed upon the *chatat* waters. Chapter 13 opens with a startling elevation of standard:

> *Extra stringencies were instituted regarding the purification process of the chatat. A person who was pure — even one who immersed for the sake of sacrificial service and stood and served upon the altar — is not pure with regard to the red-heifer process… unless he immerses himself for the sake of that process.*

Ordinary purity is not enough. Temple-grade purity is not enough. The water that removes the most severe impurity — *tumat met* — demands a dedicated intention and a dedicated immersion.

And the paradox of the mitzvah itself: the same waters purify the one who is impure through contact with death, and render impure the one who was pure and handles them. The instrument of *taharah* is not sentimental. It is exact. It costs the one who carries it.

Elul reading. *Teshuvah* is not a mood of regret. It is a *taharah* process with laws. It has a third day and a seventh day. It requires intention "for the sake of." It can defile the one who handles other people's impurity as a spectacle. The person who makes a campaign of attack out of others' sins may find that the waters he meant to sprinkle have made him *tameh*.

Chukat calls this statute a *chukah* — a decree that the intellect does not own. Elul's mercy does not cancel the *chukah*. It makes the waters available. The King in the Field does not lower the standard of purity. He walks out so that the one who needs the sprinkling can reach Him without first scaling the palace protocol.

Hidden *chesed* (Tanya) and exacting *taharah* (Rambam) belong together. Mercy that has no law becomes sentiment. Law that has no hidden *chesed* becomes a closed gate. Elul is the month in which both are true at once.

VI. Traditional Approaches and a Constructive Synthesis

The peshat of the mountains. The simple sense of Devarim 27 is a national ratification ceremony. Israel does not enter the Land on the strength of Moses' speech alone. The people must stand, hear, and answer. Covenant is not inherited as a mood. It is accepted as an oath.

The midrashic and halakhic sense. Sotah and Shevuot treat the *Amen* as binding acceptance of the whole Torah. The curses on hidden sins teach that the covenant reaches the private domain. Landmark, slander, secret idolatry — these are the places where a republic of tribes would otherwise rot.

The mussar sense. Gerizim and Ebal are inner geography. Every day a person stands between blessing and curse. *Bechirah* is not a once-in-history crossing of the Jordan. It is the structure of a moral life.

The Chassidic sense. The Alter Rebbe's Epistle 13 refuses to divide Jewry into visible *chesed* and barren *gevurah*. The *yerei Hashem* carry hidden abundance. Elul is the time appointed for that abundance to become deed. The Rashab's Hayom Yom refuses to let Elul become a war on darkness. The assignment is the building.

The civic-covenantal sense that the text itself supports. Limited power under higher law is not an imported slogan. It is the plain structure of the day. The tribes do not crown a man on Gerizim. They bind themselves. Psalm 72 asks for a king who judges the poor righteously — office as service. Psalm 75 locates raising and lowering in the hand of G-d, not in the hand of the strong. A people that can say *Amen* to a curse on secret injustice is a people that has already placed authority under law. Non-domination, in the sense that no person is available as an unmarked object for another's will, is written into "cursed be he who strikes his fellow in secret" and "cursed be he who misleads the blind." Free will is the ground of the *Amen*. Without *bechirah*, the response is noise. With it, the response is consent — and consent can be renewed. That is what *teshuvah* is, nationally and personally: the renewal of a consent that had gone silent.

Synthesis: Elul does not ask a person to choose between severity and kindness, building and battle, law and mercy. It asks that *gevurah* disclose its hidden *chesed*; that energy go to the edifice rather than the attack; that the *Amen* of the valley be spoken again over the hidden life; and that purification be undertaken as a precise avodah, not as a performance.

VII. Practical Avodah for 14 Elul

One focus for the day, not ten.

Speak one withheld *Amen* in deed. Identify a single hidden failure from the list that is actually yours — not your neighbor's: a cheapening of father or mother (including in speech at the table); a landmark moved (a boundary of honesty at work or in money); advice given that served you more than the one who asked; slander that felt like analysis; Torah known and not upheld. Do not campaign against it. Build the opposing brick today. One repaired word. One restored boundary. One check given. One portion learned aloud with a child.

That is actual *mesirat nefesh*. The hidden *chesed* does not need a new personality. It needs a time of arousal. This is the time.

Seasonal minimums, kept. Shofar. Extra Tehillim (40–42 in addition to 72–76). Tefillin and mezuzot in order. Tzedakah that costs something. The King is in the field. Walk out.

VIII. Chinuch and the Family Table

Keep this short enough to use.

1. **Two mountains.** Ask the children: if blessing stands on one hill and curse on the other, where do *we* stand? The Torah's answer is: the people stand on both. A family does not get to live only on Gerizim.

2. **Amen is a full sentence.** It is not a mutter. It means: I bind myself. Practice one real *Amen* at a *berachah* that evening — said as if the valley were listening.
3. **Blessing that overtakes.** Hashem's good runs after the one who listens. We do not have to chase every outcome. We have to hearken.
4. **Coming and going.** "Blessed when you come and blessed when you depart." The day has two doors. How we leave a room can be as holy as how we enter it. A child can understand that before any commentary.
5. **Build, don't attack.** If a sibling failed, the Hayom Yom is the family rule for Elul: put a light on. Do not organize a campaign.

IX. The Day in One Arc

Ki Tavo's fifth aliyah binds the nation with a loud *Amen* over hidden sins, then opens a blessing that pursues the one who hearkens — in city and field, in coming and going. Tehillim 72–76 set that binding under a Judge who raises and lowers, a kingship measured by justice to the poor, and a Name known in Judah. Tanya reveals that the *gevurah*-soul carries limitless hidden *chesed*, waiting for an hour of arousal that becomes deed. Rambam's red-heifer waters teach that the instrument of purity is exacting and double-edged. Hayom Yom orders the labor: do not attack; fortify the holy structure with actual self-giving.

Fourteen Elul. The King is in the field. The valley is still open. The *Amen* can still be said.

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